

CHAPTER 8

Unity in Diversity, or ‘Many in the One’

NCERT Exercise Solutions

The Big Questions	3 Q
Let’s Explore · A Rich Diversity	1 Q
Let’s Explore · Food for All	2 Q
Let’s Explore · Textiles and Clothing	4 Q
Let’s Explore · Festivals Galore	2 Q
Let’s Explore · An Epic Spread	1 Q
Questions, activities and projects	5 Q

✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

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? The Big Questions

1 What is meant by ‘unity in diversity’ in the Indian scenario?

✔ ANSWER

India has great **diversity**: many languages, scripts, dresses, foods, festivals, customs and communities.

Yet underneath this variety there is a **common thread (unity)**: shared staple grains and spices, the sari, similar festivals at the same time, and stories like the Pañchatantra, the Rāmāyaṇa and the Mahābhārata known all over India.

So ‘unity in diversity’, or the **‘Many in the One’**, means that the many forms of Indian life grow out of one shared culture. Diversity does not divide; it enriches.

2 What aspects of India’s diversity are the most striking?

✔ ANSWER

- **People and languages:** over 1.4 billion people; the ‘People of India’ project counted 4,635 communities and **325 languages using 25 scripts**.
- **Landscapes** that change as you travel.
- **Food:** thousands of different dishes.

- **Dresses and textiles:** hundreds of kinds of saris and other clothes.
- **Festivals and customs** that differ from region to region.

3 **How do we make out the unity underlying the diversity?**

✔ ANSWER

By looking for what is **common** behind the differences:

- **Food:** the same staple grains (rice, wheat, millets, dals) and spices (turmeric, cumin, cardamom, ginger) are used everywhere, in different combinations.
- **Clothing:** the sari is one dress, worn in many styles and made from many fabrics.
- **Festivals:** Makara Sankrānti is celebrated across India around 14 January under different names (Pongal, Lohri, Bihu, Uttarayan...).
- **Literature:** the Pañchatantra, Rāmāyaṇa and Mahābhārata have versions in almost every language and community.

⭐ Let's Explore · A Rich Diversity

1 **As a class activity, make lists of (1) the birthplaces of at least 5 classmates and the birthplaces of their parents; (2) the students'**

mother tongues and other languages known to them. Discuss the results in terms of diversity.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Example list (make your own with your classmates):

Student	Born in	Parents born in	Mother tongue	Other languages
Student A	Delhi	Bihar	Bhojpuri	Hindi, English
Student B	Delhi	Delhi	Hindi	English
Student C	Uttar Pradesh	Uttar Pradesh	Hindi	English, Urdu
Student D	Delhi	Punjab	Punjabi	Hindi, English
Student E	West Bengal	West Bengal	Bengali	Hindi, English

Discussion: Even in one class, families come from different States and speak different mother tongues. Many students live far from their parents' birthplace (they are 'migrants'). Most students also know a common language (like Hindi or English) to talk to each other. This shows diversity, and also unity, in a single classroom.

⭐ Let's Explore · Food for All

1 **As a class activity, make a list of ingredients (grains, spices, etc.) that are used in your home.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Sample list:

- **Grains:** rice, wheat (atta), bajra, maize
- **Pulses:** arhar (toor) dal, moong dal, masoor dal, chana, rajma
- **Spices:** turmeric, cumin (jeera), coriander, red chilli, mustard seeds, cardamom, ginger, garam masala
- **Others:** mustard oil or groundnut oil, ghee, salt, onion, garlic, tomato

Many of these are the same ingredients used in homes all over India.

2 **Take any one vegetable and think of the number of different dishes you can prepare with it.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Example: **Potato (aloo)**

- Aloo sabzi / dum aloo
- Aloo paratha
- Samosa and aloo tikki
- Aloo bonda / vada (vada pav)
- Masala dosa filling
- Aloo posto (Bengal)

- Potato chips and French fries

One vegetable (unity) gives many dishes (diversity).

⭐ Let's Explore · Textiles and Clothing

1 **Explain how the example of the sari reflects both unity and diversity (in 100–150 words).**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

The sari reflects **unity** because it is one simple dress: a plain, unstitched length of cloth worn in most parts of India. It has a very long history; a stone relief from Vaiśhali (Bihar) shows a woman in a sari a few centuries BCE.

It also reflects **diversity**. Saris are made from different fabrics: cotton, silk and now synthetic. There are famous silk saris like Banarasi, Kanjivaram, Paithani, Patan Patola, Muga and Mysore, and many cotton saris. They are made by different methods of weaving and designing, with designs woven in or printed, and in endless colours. The way of draping the sari also changes from region to region and community to community, and new ways are still being invented.

So the sari is 'one' dress that takes 'many' forms — the Many in the One.

2 **In the pictures (Fig. 8.4), can you recognise what a sari has been used for?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

The sari is used for many things besides a dress, for example:

- as a **cradle / hammock** for a baby
- to **carry a baby** tied on the body
- as a **bag** to carry things (vegetables, grains)
- as a **head pad** to carry loads on the head
- as a **curtain or screen**
- to **filter or dry** things (check the picture in your book)

3 **Are you aware of, or can you imagine, more uses for the sari?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Old saris are stitched into **quilts (like kantha)**, bedsheets and pillow covers.
- Used as a **rope** or swing.
- Cut into **cloth bags**, dusters and towels.
- Used as a **sunshade** or to cover grain and food.
- Used as a **mosquito net** or blanket.

4 **Following the example of the sari, make a list of different styles you have seen for the dhoti — both as regards the fabric and the uses the**

dhoti can be put to. What conclusion can you draw?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Styles and names: dhoti (north India), veshti / mundu (Tamil Nadu, Kerala), panche (Karnataka), dhuti (Bengal), lungi (a coloured, wrapped cloth). It can be tied short or long, with or without pleats.

Fabrics: cotton, silk, khadi; plain white or with a coloured or golden (zari) border.

Uses: worn daily or on festivals and ceremonies; also used as a towel, a head cloth (turban), to carry things, or as a sheet.

Conclusion: Like the sari, the dhoti is **one simple unstitched cloth** worn all over India, but in **many styles, fabrics and uses**. It is another example of unity in diversity.

⭐ Let's Explore · Festivals Galore

1. **What is your favourite festival and how is it celebrated in your region? Do you know whether it is celebrated in any other part of India, maybe under a different name?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Sample answer: My favourite festival is **Makar Sankranti**. In my region we take a holy dip, eat khichdi and sweets made of til (sesame) and jaggery, and fly kites.

It is celebrated all over India around 14 January under different names: **Lohri / Maghi** (Punjab), **Khichdi Parv** (Uttar Pradesh, Bihar), **Uttarayan** (Gujarat), **Magh Bihu** (Assam), **Poush Sankranti** (West Bengal), **Pongal** (Tamil Nadu), **Pedda Panduga** (Andhra Pradesh), **Makara Vilakku** (Kerala).

2 **During October–November, many major festivals take place in India. Make a list of the few main ones and their various names in different parts of the country.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Festival	Other names / forms
Dussehra	Vijayadashami; Durga Puja (West Bengal); Navratri with garba (Gujarat); Mysuru Dasara (Karnataka); Bathukamma (Telangana)
Diwali	Deepavali (south India); Kali Puja (West Bengal); Bandi Chhor Divas (Sikhs)
Day after Diwali	Govardhan Puja / Annakut; Bali Pratipada (Maharashtra, Karnataka)
Bhai Dooj	Bhau Beej (Maharashtra); Bhai Phonta (West Bengal); Bhai Tika
Chhath Puja	Bihar, Jharkhand, eastern Uttar Pradesh
Guru Nanak Jayanti	Gurpurab, Prakash Parv

⭐ Let's Explore · An Epic Spread

1 **In a class discussion, try to identify the episode depicted in the painting shown in Fig. 8.6 (Yuddha Kanda of Ramayana, Sahibdin, Mewar, 1652) and important details associated with it.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

The painting is from the **Yuddha Kāṇḍa** (the 'Book of War') of the Rāmāyaṇa. It shows the **battle in Laṅkā** between Rāma's army (Rāma, Lakṣhmaṇa, Hanuman and the vānara army) and the army of the demon king **Rāvaṇa** (check the picture in your book).

Details: Rāvaṇa had kidnapped Sītā; Rāma fights to bring her back and to re-establish dharma. It was painted by **Sahibdin** in **Mewar** in **1652**, and is now in the India Office Library, London.

❓ Questions, activities and projects

1 **Conduct a class discussion on the two quotations at the start of the chapter:**
Tagore: "Oh, grant me my prayer, that I may never lose the bliss of the touch of the one in the play of the many."
Sri Aurobindo: "The principle of unity in diversity … the Many in the One, would place

her on the sure foundation of her Swabhava and Swadharma."

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Tagore prays that while enjoying the many different things in life (the 'play of the many'), he should never forget the one thing that connects them all (the 'touch of the one').

Sri Aurobindo says that unity in diversity has always been natural to India; it is India's very nature. If India follows this principle, the 'Many in the One', she will stand firm on her own nature (*swabhava*) and her own duty (*swadharma*).

Common idea: both say that India's many languages, foods, dresses and festivals are not separate; they come from one shared culture. We should enjoy diversity but always remember the unity behind it.

2 **Select a few stories from the Pañchatantra and discuss how their message is still valid today. Do you know of any similar stories from your region?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- **The Monkey and the Crocodile:** keep calm and think quickly in danger; be careful whom you trust. Still useful when facing tricks, including online fraud.

- **The Tortoise and the Geese:** the tortoise opens its mouth to talk and falls. Message: speak only when needed; do not be proud.
- **The Lion and the Hare:** a small hare tricks a strong lion into jumping into a well. Message: intelligence is stronger than strength.
- **The Brahmin and the Mongoose:** do not act in haste without checking the facts. Today: do not believe rumours or forward messages without checking.

Similar stories from many regions include the **Jātaka tales** and **Hitopadesha**, and local folk tales told by grandparents with animal characters and a moral.

3 **Collect a few folk tales from your region and discuss their message.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Sample: **Akbar–Birbal** stories: Birbal solves problems with wit. Message: clever thinking solves problems.

Tenali Rāma (Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka): a witty poet teaches lessons with humour. Message: use your mind to defeat greed and pride.

Gopal Bhar (Bengal): a clever jester. Message: humour and good sense can win over power.

Collect tales from your grandparents or neighbours and write the moral of each.

4 **Is there any ancient story that you have seen being depicted through a form of art? It could be a sculpture, a painting, a dance performance, a movie ... Discuss with your classmates.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Yes. Examples:

- **Ramlila**: the Rāmāyaṇa is acted every year before Dussehra in many towns and villages.
- **Kathakali** (Kerala) dancers perform scenes from the Mahābhārata and Rāmāyaṇa.
- **Paintings** like the Mewar Rāmāyaṇa (Fig. 8.6) and **sculptures** on temple walls show scenes from the epics.
- **TV serials, films and cartoons** on the Rāmāyaṇa, the Mahābhārata and Hanuman.

This shows how one story is told in many art forms — unity in diversity.

5 **Discuss in class the following quotation by Jawaharlal Nehru, from his travels in India before Independence:**

"Everywhere I found a cultural background which had exerted a powerful influence on their lives. ... The old epics of India, the Ramayana and the Mahabharata ... were widely known among the masses ... Illiterate villagers would know hundreds of verses by heart and their conversation would be full of

references to them or to some story with a moral ...”

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Nehru saw that wherever he went in India, people shared a **common cultural background**.

The Rāmāyaṇa and the Mahābhārata were known to ordinary people through translations and retellings in their own languages. Even villagers who could not read knew hundreds of verses by heart and used the stories and morals in daily talk.

This shows that culture is passed on **orally**, not only through books, and that the epics **united people** across regions and languages. It is a strong example of unity in diversity.

🎉 **Chapter 8 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**